

Skyscrapers

More than any other structure, the first skyscrapers of the late 19th century showed how site, purpose and materials exerted control over a building's design. Until this time, towers and church steeples had relied of necessity on thick or buttressed load-bearing walls: the liberation of tall buildings came through a mix of factors including a high premium on urban land, the use of steel in structural frameworks, and the evolution of the modern elevator. (Steam-driven safety elevators arrived in the 1850s, followed by electric models from 1902.)

The first major opportunity to exploit these new technologies came in the city of Chicago, largely rebuilt in the decades following the fire of 1871. William Le Baron Jenney's (1832–1907) ten-storey Home Insurance Building (opposite, 1884–5) was the first tall building to use fireproof steel as its framework, launching a revolution that would transform Chicago's skyline and, with it, modern architecture. As skyscrapers grew taller, tiered designs were developed to ensure light and fresh air reached street level.

